

Each liverwort can grow to several metres across over many years.



Liverwort

Step back in time 470 million years and you wouldn't see any animals on the land. No dinosaurs, no mammals, not even insects. However, you would see plants — bright-green liverworts. Liverworts are simple plants that don't have any roots, veins, stems, or flowers. Without stems, they can't grow very tall. Instead, they have to creep across soil or rocks, lurking only in damp and dark places.

Occasionally, liverworts sprout what look like tiny umbrellas. These don't keep off rain though. They help the liverwort make spores — seed-like particles from which new liverworts grow. Liverworts can also reproduce from miniature copies of themselves made in little cups on their surface.